Zimmerman Lab Progress Reports

Progress reports serve as a dual-purpose mechanism within the laboratory, balancing administrative necessity with professional growth.

Administrative Accountability: Progress reports function as a formal reporting tool to track project milestones and researcher status on a monthly basis. This documentation is essential for maintaining compliance with sponsored programs and funding agencies, such as the NIH, as it provides a transparent record of how resources are utilized and how specific research aims are being met. As a result, progress reports serve to help keep the lab in compliance with formal requirements.

Professional & Analytical Development: Progress reports also serve as a fundamental pedagogical tool designed to integrate students and researchers into an iterative analytical cycle. By translating complex data into written summaries and visual slide decks, researchers practice the essential skill of articulating technical ideas clearly—a direct prerequisite for formal research talks and academic defense. Furthermore, the reporting process compels researchers to look beyond simply running more experiments and encourages a deeper interpretation of results and a critical evaluation of their implications for the broader project. As a result, these reports provide a structured framework to guide your thinking, refine your technical communication, and focus your research potential.

Due Date

Progress reports are due on the last Thursday of each month. These should be submitted prior to working hours on the following Friday.

Slide Template

Progress reports should make use of the default lab template, which can be found on the sharepoint under the following link (default slides)

Report Format:

Progress reports should be formatted as powerpoint slides and are generally between 7-14 slides in length. This should contain key findings that have been produced within the last reporting period (typically one month).

Title Slide: Should clearly state the researcher’s name along with the specific month and year of the reporting period. This ensures that all records are easily archivable and identifiable for longitudinal tracking.

Summary Slide: This slide serves as an introduction and should provide a high-level overview of the month’s activities. Each active project should be listed as a primary bullet point, supported by a sub-list of one-to-four key takeaways. These should preview the detailed data that is to come in the remaining slides. Additionally, researchers may include a section for general laboratory activities. This entry highlights substantial contributions to the lab environment—such as site visits, peer training, or grant preparation—that require significant time commitments outside of primary project tasks, but may not necessarily warrant their own slide.

Research Slides: These constitute the core of your progress report and must be structured around a clear, stated objective for each experiment or task. To ensure the deck is effective as a standalone document, slides should be designed for maximum readability and clarity without the need for verbal explanation. This is achieved by including concise bullet points or captions for every image, chart, or diagram presented.

To maintain analytical rigor, each data set must be accompanied by at least one sentence that explains its significance and your interpretation of the findings. For enhanced scannability, you are encouraged to include a "main takeaway" summarized in a grey highlighted box at the bottom of the slide. This format ensures that the most critical information is immediately accessible to any reviewer. Furthermore, please explicitly indicate if any presented data is a video, as these files will not play in PDF format. To ensure technical accuracy, all visual data must feature clear scale bars, and any **notional data representing expected results MUST BE CLEARLY MARKED as such** to distinguish it from empirical findings.

Future Outlook Slide: This slide acts as a strategic mirror to the Summary Slide, utilizing primary bullet points for each ongoing project to outline the next phase of the research. This section should detail upcoming milestones, experimental goals, and the specific outcomes you hope to achieve in the near future. By clearly articulating these "next steps," the slide serves to align your immediate tasks with the project's long-term objectives, ensuring continued momentum and a focused research trajectory.

Submission Format

To be considered complete, progress reports should be submitted in two ways. First, the completed powerpoint slides should be uploaded to the sharepoint folder under the appropriate month (Sharepoint link). Second, an email should be sent to the PI with the following format.

Email title: Last Name – Progress report – Month, Year
(e.g. "Zimmerman – Progress Report – April, 2026")

Email Contents: Email should contain 3-4 bullet points indicating your most important progress to report this month, and 2-3 bullet points indicating your future plans.

Link to Sharepoint: Email should contain a link to your powerpoint slides on the sharepoint

PDF Attachment: Email should also contain a .pdf attachment of your progress report (allows progress reports to be references from a mobile format compared to .pptx)

See example email below for format

Example Email

Hello John,
Attached below is a PDF copy of my progress report for April 2026. In summary, it includes the following:

1. *PEW Biomedical scholar grant*
2. *Initial FRJS nanofiber spinning*
3. *Initial hIPSC-CM cell culture*

Future Research Plans:

1. *Manufacture working MTFs*
2. *Fabricate single cell island wafer patterns*
3. *Katz RO1 grant submission*

Sharepoint Link

Best Regards,
John Zimmerman